THE WEIGHT OF THE WAVES

R. A. MIRANDA

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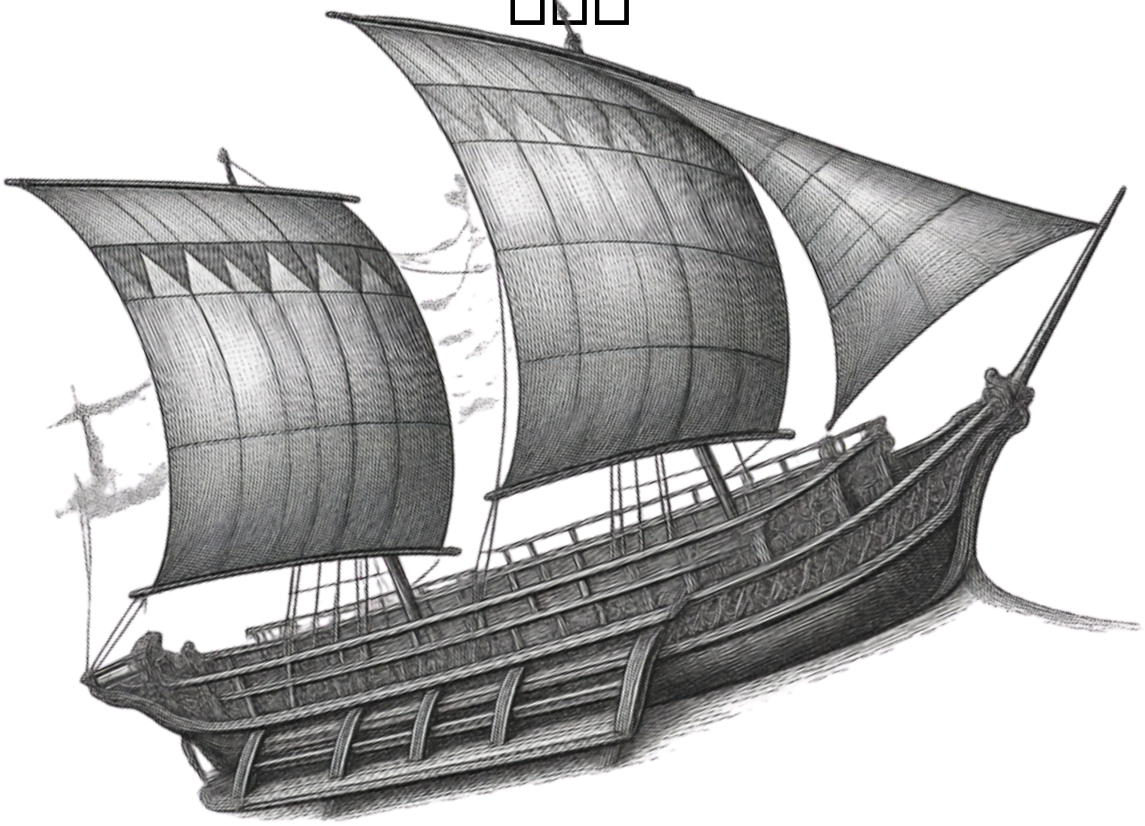
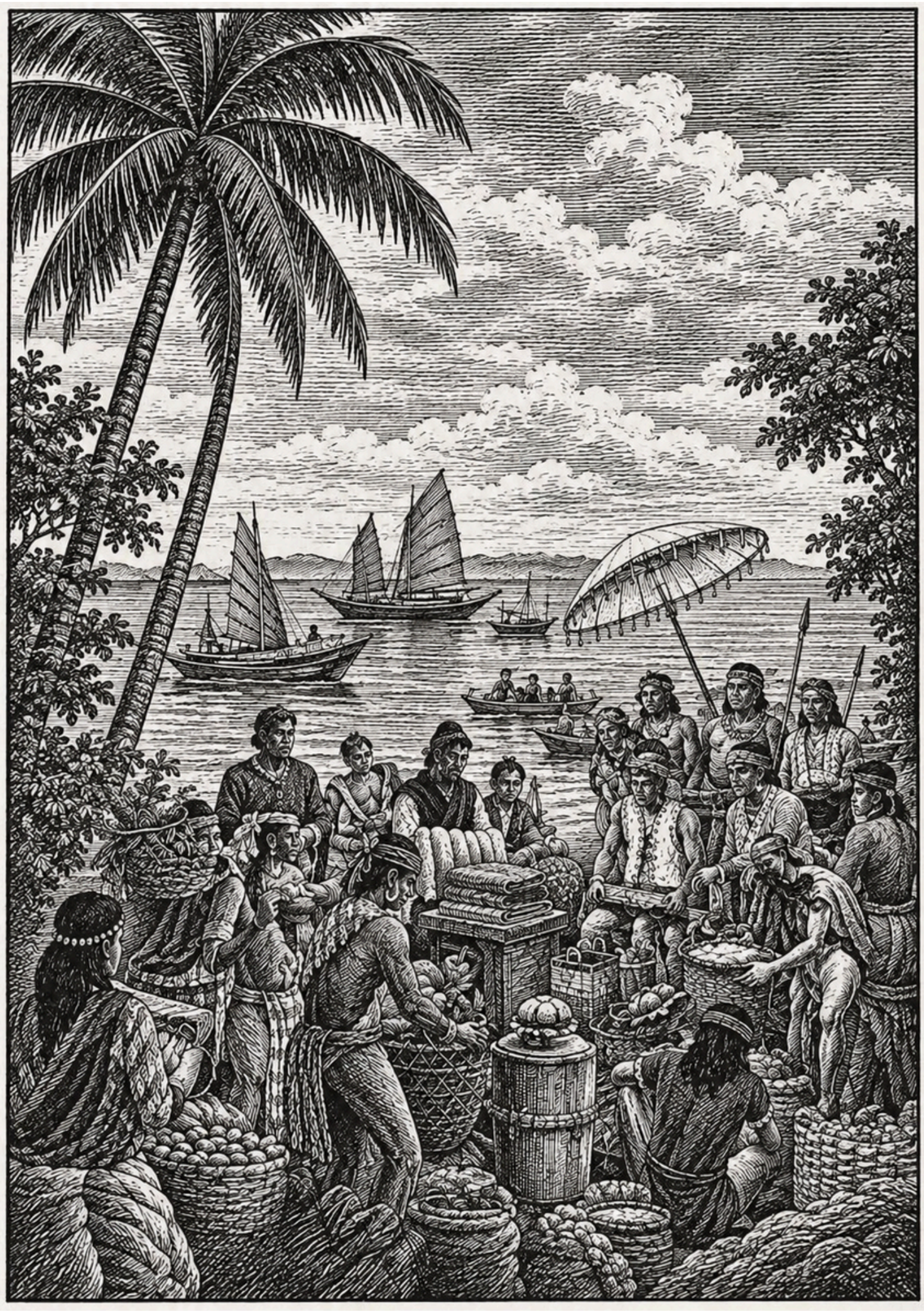


R. A. MIRANDA

To those who stood and fought before me, to the people who called this land home long before it was known as the Philippines. To our ancestors, whose names may have been lost to time, but whose lives were once filled with the same hopes, fears, and dreams we carry today.

This story is for you. May we never forget that before foreign hands shaped our history, we already had a world of our own, one worth remembering, honoring, and telling.

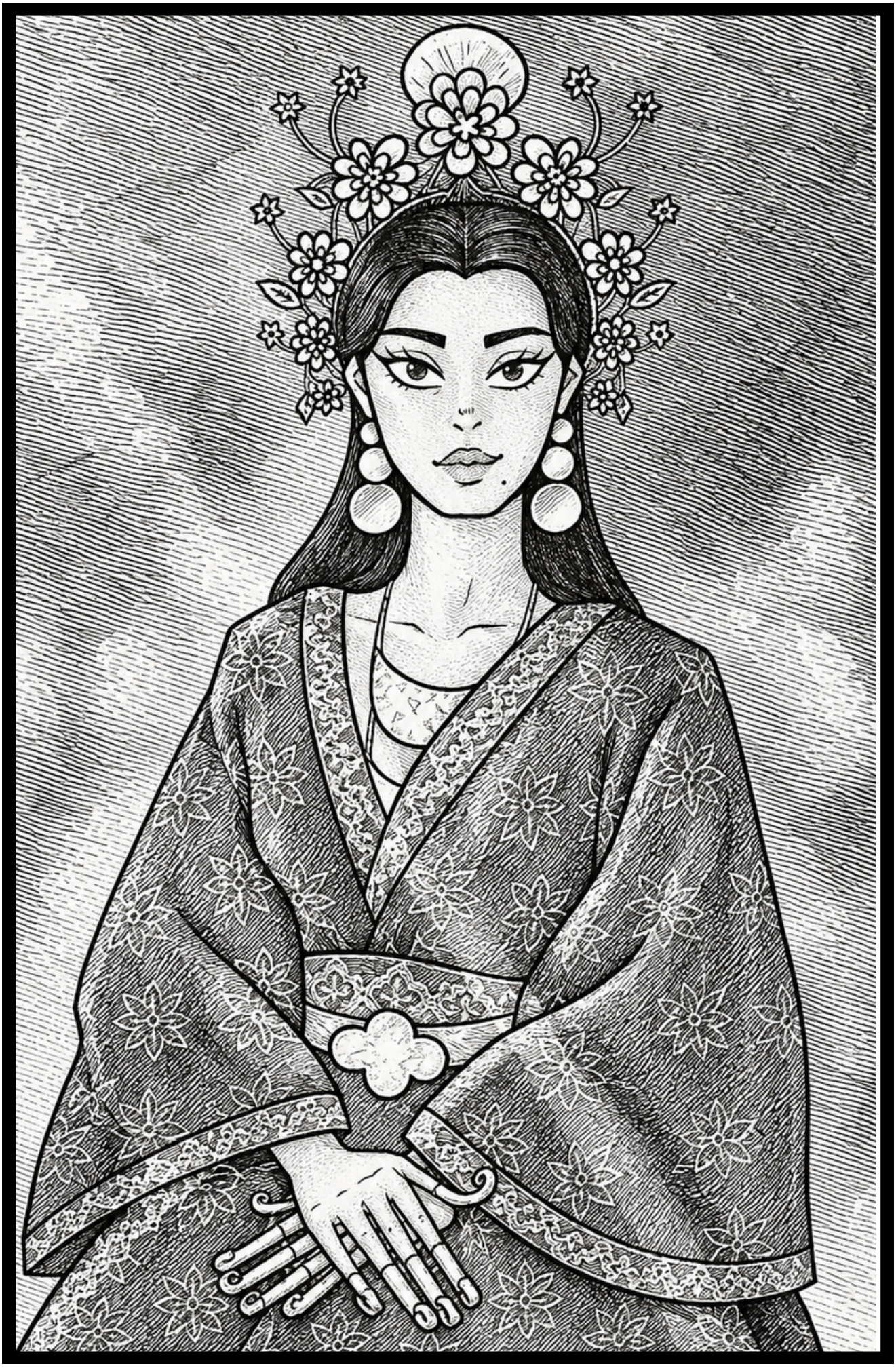


Long ago, in a divided realm of what is now known as the Republic of the Philippines, there stood numerous great kingdoms, ruled by Rajas, Datus, and Sultans. Located in the very heart of these lands was the Kingdom of Marilag.

The sea had always been kind to Marilag. It brought merchants to its shores, filled fishermen's nets with fish, and carried balangays toward distant lands. For hundreds of years, the people had lived by its blessings, believing that tomorrow would bring another good harvest and another peaceful day.

But one morning, the sea was quiet, and the people had little reason to celebrate.

From the palace balcony, Dayang Hiraya, Princess of Marilag, watched fishermen return with nearly empty balangays. Farmers carried away ruined crops, while mothers waited for rice that was becoming harder to find. Yet inside the palace, servants and uripons prepared a grand feast for the coming Pista ng Pag-ani.



Hiraya turned away from the sight. She could not understand how a kingdom could appear so wealthy while leaving so many of its people hungry.

As the heir of Raja Lakandula and his first wife, Hara Marikit, Hiraya knows that someday everything in Marilag would be hers to rule and protect. She was taught the traditions of her people, the rules and customs of the court and the responsibilities expected of a future Hara. Until that time, she had believed that as a Dayang it meant learning how to rule. She had yet to understand that ruling and serving were not two different duties.

A few days later, Raja Lakandula called a meeting with his trusted datus. The kingdom's problems had grown worse. Several merchant boats had disappeared without a trace, and merchants who once filled the ports of Marilag had begun choosing other routes. Neighboring rulers had also become less willing to trade with them.

The council feared that Marilag was slowly being isolated. There was one power, however, that seemed willing to help.

The Sultanate of Akbar, a powerful maritime sultanate beyond Marilag's southern waters, had offered grain, ships, and protection for Marilag's trade routes. Its ruler, Sultan Jalal, controlled a powerful fleet, while his eldest son, Ladja Makusug, was the heir to the sultanate. Akbar's offer appeared generous. There was only one condition. Hiraya would marry Makusug.

The marriage, according to the Akbari envoys, would unite the two realms and guarantee peace for generations. Akbar would provide food while Marilag recovered from its poor harvest, and its ships would protect Marilag's waters from pirates and rival kingdoms. As soon as Raja made the offer, Hiraya was almost stunned at the proposal and could hardly believe her own ears. She was not able to fathom the fact that Akbar was willing to offer so much to the kingdom which has so little to offer to him in return.

Raja Lakandula reminded her that the future ruler is supposed not to only think of her own wishes, but also about the safety of thousands of people. Hiraya was aware of his concern but was still uncertain about the proposal. Akbar made the offer of help only after Marilag had become weak, which raised a lot of suspicion.

That night, Hiraya walked around the palace grounds until she came to the last narra tree where Bai Muntad, the Head Babaylan and the elder of the community is usually carrying out prayers to the Anito. Hiraya shared her concern about the marriage proposal and the terrible consequences of refusing it.

Bai Muntad listened to her quietly and then gazed at the immense sea. Bai Muntad stated that a river can change its course without forgetting its origins. Traditions teach us where we come from, but at the same time the ruler

Before Ladja Makusug and the Akbari envoys could arrive, a powerful storm struck Marilag. The winds broke balays. Rain flooded the fields, and families were forced to leave their homes.

The river rose so high that several barangays could no longer reach the capital.

The Raja ordered his advisers to distribute the remaining food, but the council could not agree. Some datus argued that the royal and noble households should receive supplies first to preserve the strength of the kingdom's leadership. Hiraya could not bear to watch the people suffer while the elders argued.

She gathered fifty-five fishermen and asked them to use their balangays to carry food to the flooded barangays. Farmers and villagers were encouraged to share whatever remained of their harvest. Hiraya also opened part of the royal granaries and personally helped families whose homes had been destroyed.

At first, some people doubted her because she had never led such an effort before. But she continued. For the first time, many of the people of Marilag saw their future Hara not standing above them, but standing beside them.

When the storm finally passed, many families had survived because of the efforts of Hiraya and the community. But the kingdom's food reserves were nearly empty.

Raja Lakandula was disappointed when he learned that Hiraya had opened the royal granaries without his permission. He reminded her that there might be another disaster and that the kingdom could not survive by giving away everything it possessed. Hiraya understood his concern. Yet she also knew that allowing people to starve while food remained locked inside the palace could not be the answer.

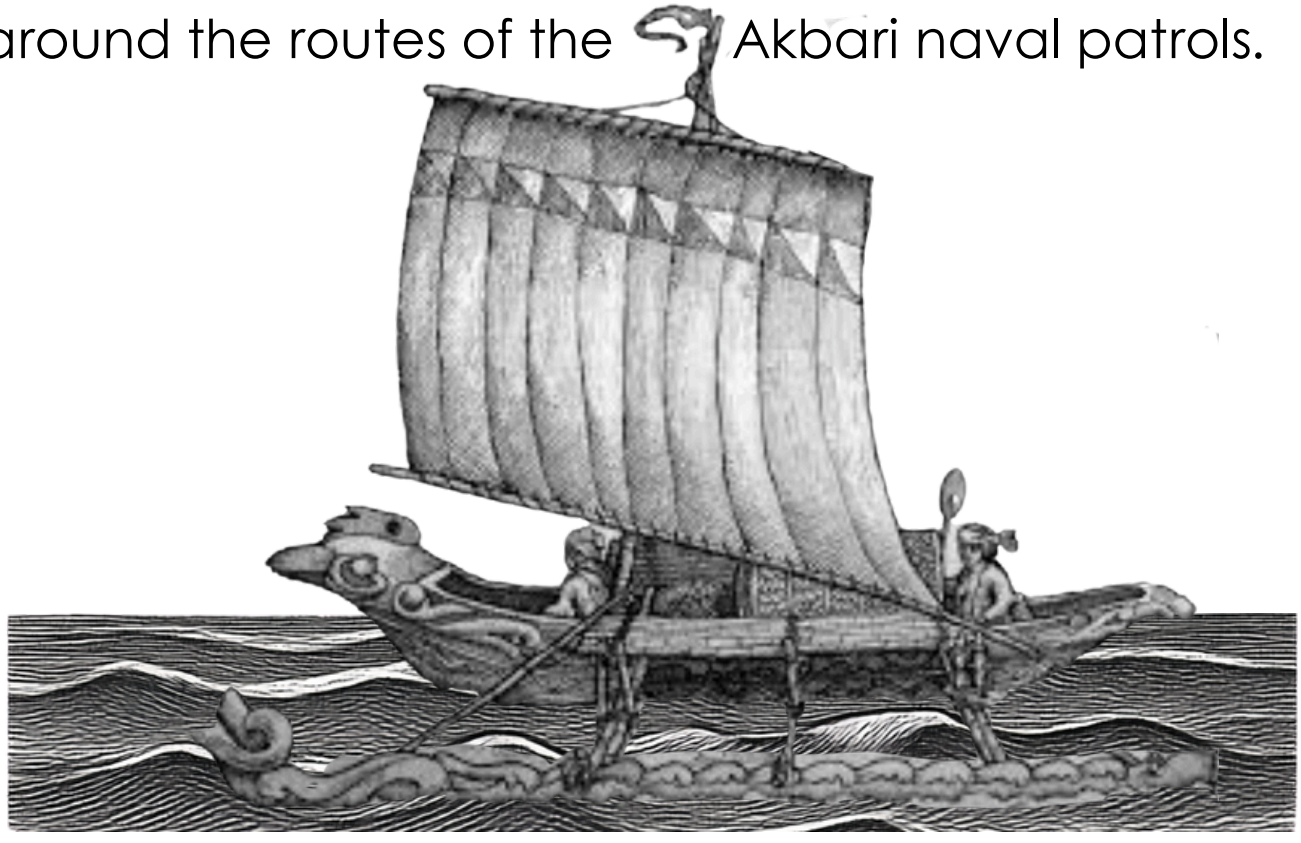
Before father and daughter could settle their disagreement, horns also known as tambulis sounded throughout the palace. The delegation from the Sultanate of Akbar had arrived. At the center of the delegation was Ladja Makusug.

He walked into the palace with the confidence expected of a future sultan. He was accompanied by Akbari warriors and diplomats who were more than what Hiraya expected in a delegation that claimed to come in peace.

Makusug brought to Hiraya the proposal of Sultan Jalal. Akbar was to send grains, soldiers and ships in order for Marilag to recover from the flooding. However, the marriage proposal had to be preserved. The offer was even more generous after the flood, but it may also contain dangers.

Hraya tried to find the roots of the problems that had concerned Marilag long before the flood had hit the land. She checked the records of the missing merchant vessels and questioned the fishermen who operated in the waters of Marilag.

What she found out was highly disturbing. The disappearance of the vessels was not a mere coincidence. The majority of cases happened around the routes of the Akbari naval patrols.



Later, an old sailor showed her a piece of blue fabric with the symbol of Akbar. The sailor referred to the remaining sailors that had survived and told about armed men dressed in similar outfits.

But the pieces began to fit together. The merchant ships disappeared. Marilag's trade weakened. Merchants began avoiding its ports. The kingdom's food became scarce.

Then Akbar arrived with grain and protection. And in exchange, they wanted Hiraya to marry their heir. The more she thought about it, the more she feared that Akbar had not simply discovered Marilag's weakness. They had been waiting for it.

When Hiraya encountered Makusug again, she found him more difficult to understand than she expected. He did not behave like an enemy. He spoke respectfully to the people of Marilag and showed concern for the families affected by the storm.

Yet he knew less about his father's plans than Hiraya expected. Makusug admitted that Sultan Jalal believed Marilag was too valuable to remain weak.

Its location gave it access to important maritime routes, fertile lands, and a harbor that could strengthen Akbar's control over trade. The marriage would not simply unite two royal families. It would place Marilag's future closer to the hands of Akbar.

Makusug did not know whether his father had ordered the attacks on the merchant ships. But his uncertainty only made Hiraya more worried. If Akbar had created the very conditions that made Marilag desperate for protection, then their offer was not an act of friendship. It was a carefully prepared opportunity.

Soon after, Raja Lakandula called another council meeting. The Akbari envoys repeated their terms. Akbar would provide food, protection, and military support, but only if the marriage between Hiraya and Makusug was honored. The council seemed ready to accept.

Hiraya entered the chamber wearing the saya garment prepared by her family for the engagement. Around her body were gold pieces of jewelry passed down through the women of her lineage for generations.

Everyone expected her to accept the agreement. Instead, she walked toward the center of the chamber. She spoke of the missing ships, the merchants who had abandoned Marilag, and the strange timing of Akbar's offer.

Then she placed the torn blue cloth on the council table. The chamber fell silent. The Akbari envoys dismissed it as insufficient evidence. They argued that a piece of cloth could not prove the actions of an entire sultanate.

Hiraya knew they were right. She did not have enough evidence to accuse Akbar of attacking Marilag. But she did not need absolute proof to understand the danger of surrendering her kingdom's independence. She removed the gold jewelry from her body and placed it beside the cloth.

She had been born into the royal family, and she would not turn away from the responsibilities placed upon her. But she refused to inherit a kingdom that survived only because its people were forced to surrender their freedom.

Instead of accepting Akbar's terms, she proposed a different agreement. Marilag would protect its own waters while cooperating with Akbar against pirates and other threats. The two kingdoms could trade food during times of shortage, assist one another after disasters and keep trade routes open.

But there would be no marriage requirement. No kingdom would gain control over another through a royal union. The proposal shocked the council. The Akbari envoys exchanged uneasy glances. Their smiles had disappeared.

One of them finally stepped forward and warned that rejecting the Sultanate of Akbar could have consequences. Hiraya did not step back. “If peace depends on our obedience,” she said, “then it was never peace to begin with.”

The chamber erupted in whispers. Raja Lakandula looked at his daughter. For a moment, pride replaced the worry in his eyes. Then a loud crash came from outside. The palace doors burst open. Akbari soldiers rushed into the chamber.

The council was thrown into chaos. Datus reached for their weapons while servants and villagers fled from the room. The Akbari envoys remained still, their silence revealing that the attack was not unexpected.

Raja Lakandula immediately stepped in front of Hiraya. “Take my daughter and leave,” he ordered the guards. Hiraya refused to move.

The Raja drew his weapon and faced the soldiers who had entered his own palace. He fought to give his daughter and the council enough time to escape, but the Akbari forces were too many.

A soldier struck him down. Hiraya froze. “Father!” She tried to reach him, but several guards pulled her away as more soldiers entered the chamber. Raja Lakandula looked toward his daughter from the floor. His voice was weak, but his eyes remained steady.

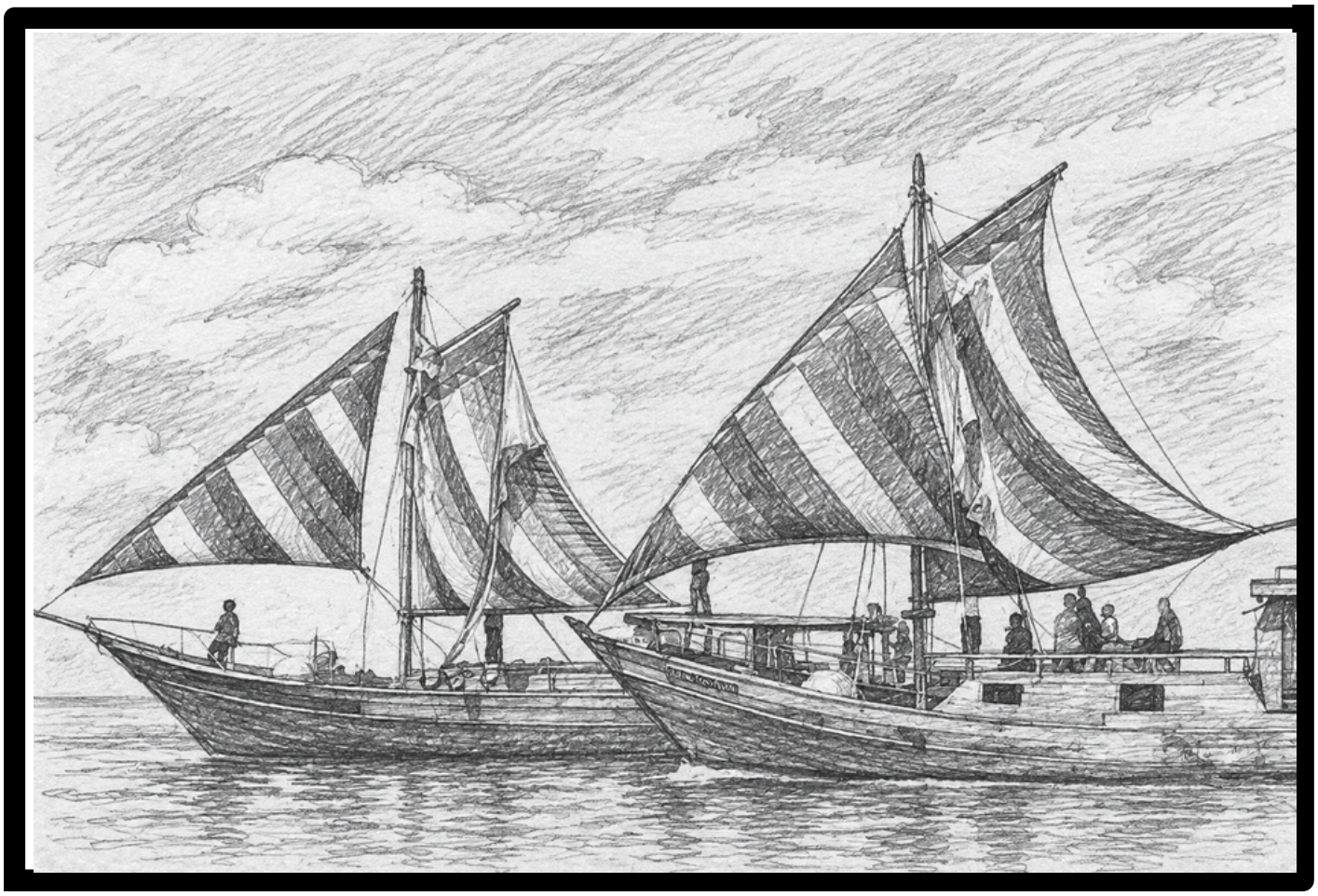
"Do not let them decide what Marilag becomes.” Those were his final words. The Raja of Marilag was dead. For a moment, everything seemed to stop.

Hiraya stared at the place where her father had fallen. The man she had spent days arguing with, the man she had believed did not understand her, was gone. But there was no time to grieve. The soldiers were already moving through the palace.

The Akbari envoys announced that Sultan Jalal had taken control of Marilag's royal court. With the Raja dead and the kingdom weakened, they declared that the marriage between Hiraya and Makusug would now secure the future of both realms. Hiraya finally understood the truth. The marriage had never been a proposal. It had been a plan.

Akbar had waited for Marilag to become weak, offered help when the kingdom was desperate, and expected the royal family to surrender its independence willingly. When Hiraya refused, they had simply chosen another way.

But they had made one mistake. They had underestimated the people of Marilag. The Akbari soldiers quickly took control of the palace, the harbor, and the roads leading toward the capital. They expected the kingdom to surrender after the death of its Raja.



Instead, resistance began almost immediately. The fishermen who had once carried food through the flooded barangays refused to transport supplies for the Akbari army. Farmers hid their harvests instead of surrendering them. Villagers warned one another whenever Akbari soldiers approached.

Even some of the datus who had once argued among themselves now stood together. They had followed Hiraya during the storm. Now they followed her again.

Hiraya was taken away from the palace before she could organize the resistance.

The Akbari soldiers intended to keep her under watch until she agreed to the marriage and publicly accepted Sultan Jalal's authority. But Makusug intervened.

He had watched his father's soldiers take control of Marilag and had finally understood what the marriage was truly meant to accomplish. It was never meant to unite two kingdoms as equals. It was meant to place Marilag under Akbar's influence.

Makusug secretly helped Hiraya escape the palace through an old passage used by the royal family during times of danger. He knew that by doing so, he was betraying his father's orders.

But he also knew that remaining silent would make him no better than the men who had taken the kingdom by force. That night, Hiraya secretly returned to the old narra tree where Bai Muntad had once spoken to her about changing the course of a river.

Hiraya knelt beneath its branches, still wearing the remnants of the gold jewelry she had refused to take back from the council table. “My father is dead,” she whispered. Bai Muntad sat beside her.

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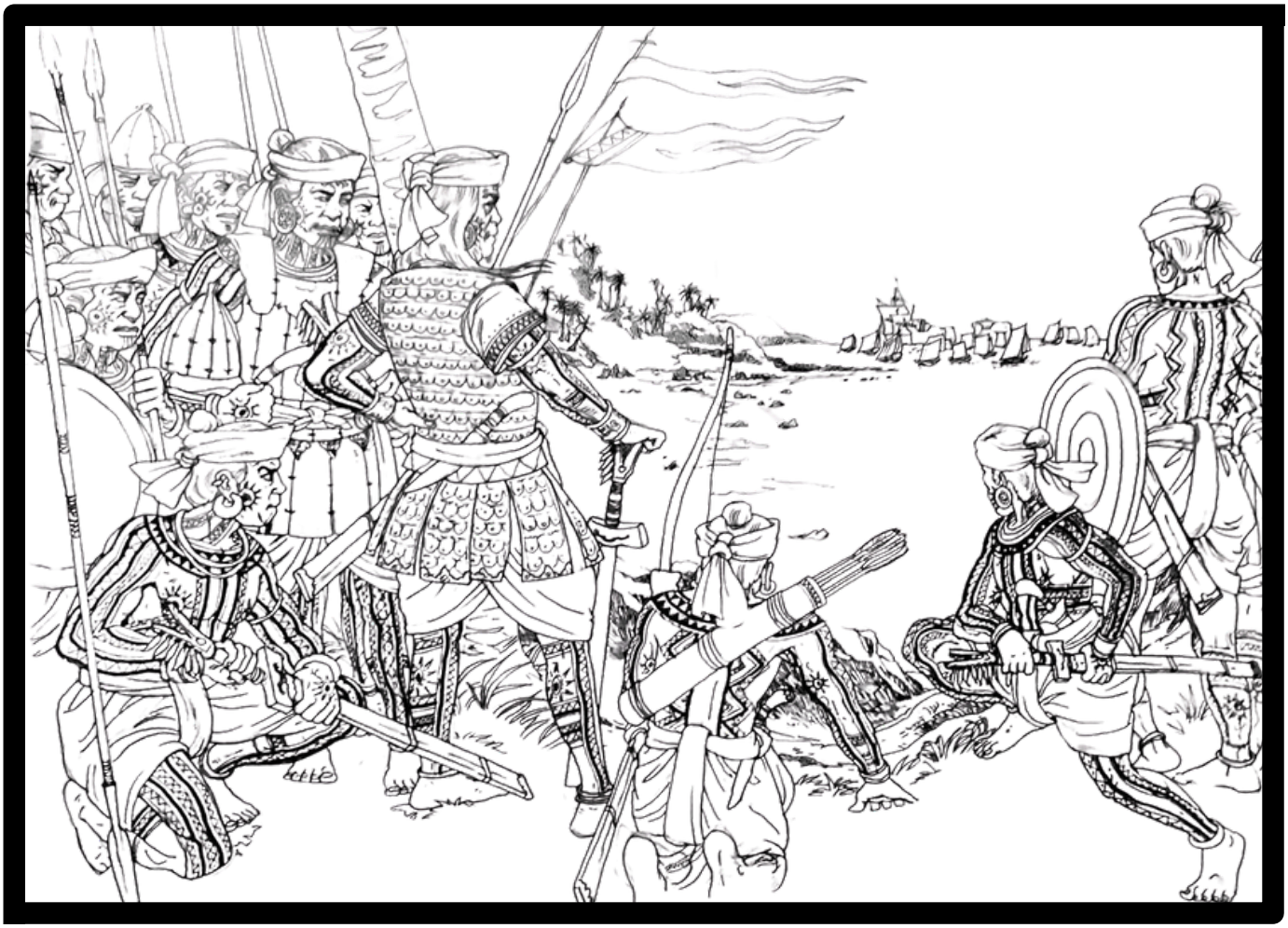
“You have lost your father,” the old woman said, “but you have not lost your kingdom.” Hiraya looked toward the sea. The waves struck the shore again and again. For the first time, she understood what her father had carried all his life. The kingdom was not simply land, wealth, or a throne.

It was every fisherman who depended on the sea. Every farmer who planted beneath the sun. Every mother waiting for food. Every child playing along the shore. Every person who believed that Marilag was home.

The next morning, Hiraya began organizing the resistance. The fishermen used their knowledge of the waters to prevent Akbari ships from reaching certain coastal villages. Farmers carried messages between settlements. Datus who had once disagreed with one another began working together.

They did not fight the Akbari army through strength alone. They knew their land better. They knew which rivers could be crossed at low tide, which forests concealed old paths, and which narrow passages could prevent large groups of soldiers from advancing.

For weeks, Marilag resisted. The Akbari forces expected a kingdom without its Raja to be easy to control. Instead, every village became another place where their authority was challenged. Eventually, the Akbari soldiers were forced to retreat toward the coast. Their supplies had begun to run low, and the people they had expected to control refused to cooperate with them.



The final confrontation came at the harbor. Akbari ships waited beyond the shore while their remaining soldiers attempted to reach them. Hiraya stood with the fishermen and datus who had defended Marilag since the day of the invasion.

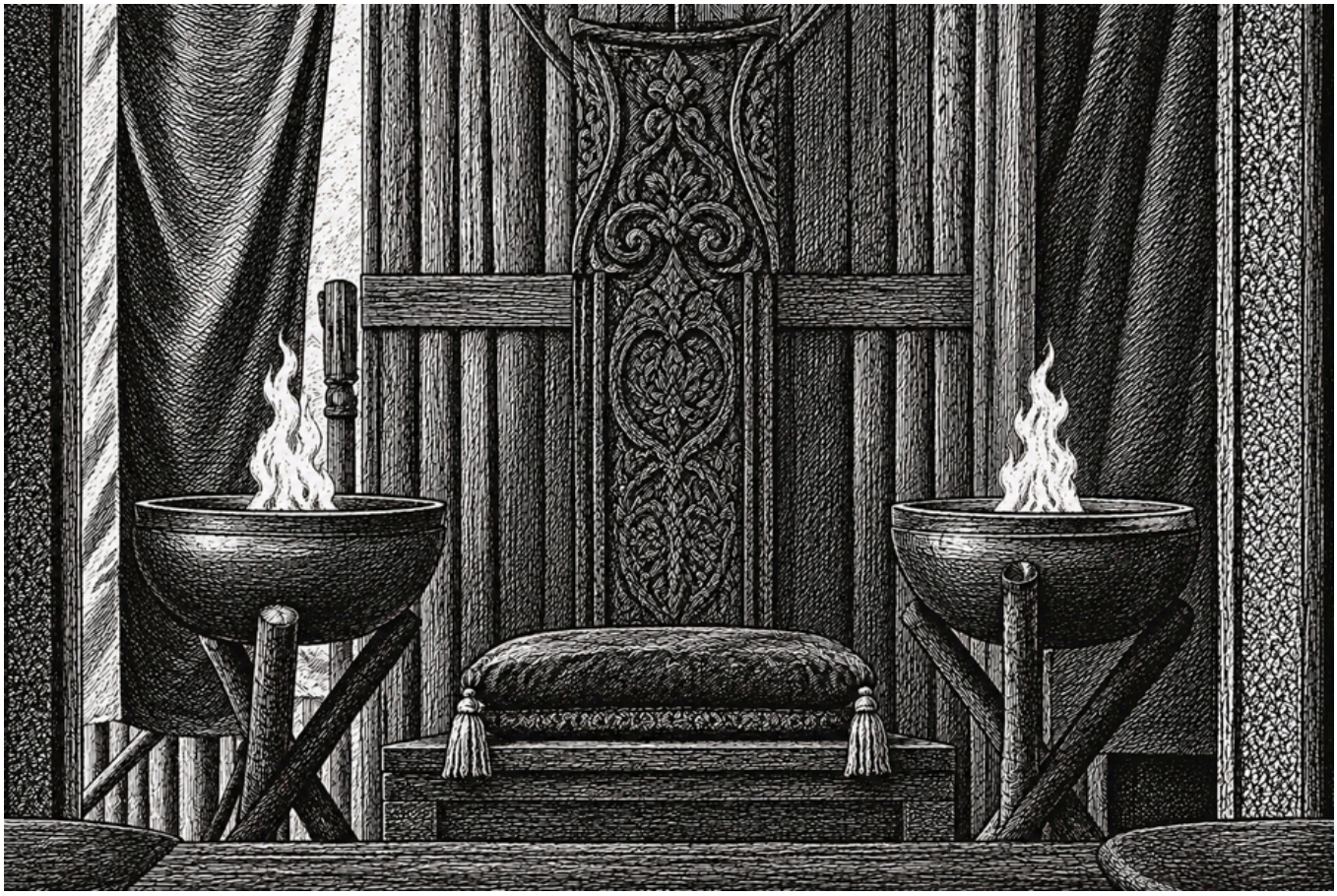
Among them stood Makusug. He had removed the colors of Akbar from his clothing. The heir of the sultanate now stood beside the kingdom his father had tried to take. When the last Akbari soldiers reached the harbor, they found the path to their ships blocked.

Their invasion had failed. The remaining soldiers surrendered and were allowed to leave Marilag under the condition that they would take no people or supplies with them.

Makusug remained behind. He knew that returning to Akbar would mean answering to Sultan Jalal for his betrayal. Hiraya did not ask him to stay, nor did she promise that Marilag would forgive him.

He had helped her, but he was still the son of the ruler who had invaded her kingdom. For the first time, their two kingdoms stood on opposite sides of a decision that could not be solved by marriage.

The Akbari ships eventually disappeared beyond the horizon. Marilag was free once again. But freedom came with a cost. Raja Lakandula was dead.bThe palace had been damaged, the royal court was divided, and many families had lost their homes.



Hiraya knew that restoring the kingdom would take years. That night, she returned to the palace. Her father's throne stood empty. She approached it but did not sit. Not yet.

She looked toward the sea instead. She had once believed that becoming Hara meant inheriting a throne. Now she understood that the throne was the least essential she could inherit from her father.

What he had left her was a responsibility. A kingdom to protect. A people to serve. And a future that she would have to build herself. The following morning, Hiraya returned to the palace balcony where it had all begun.

Below her, children played along the beach while fishermen prepared their balangays for another journey. The sea was no longer empty. Marilag was wounded, but it was still standing.

The people had discovered that they could stand together when their leaders were willing to listen. And Hiraya had discovered that leadership was not simply about carrying a crown.

A crown could be inherited. A kingdom could be claimed. But neither could truly belong to a ruler who did not care for the people beneath it.

The ocean had ceased to be calm. Waves crashed against the shore as fishermen raised their sails, carrying not only the hope of another harvest, but the determination to protect the land they called home.

Hiraya watched them disappear beyond the horizon. She finally understood the weight of the waves. They were not the weight of the sea itself, but the weight of every life carried upon it. And now, with her father's crown waiting for her, she was no longer afraid to carry it.

THE END.

IMAGE CREDITS AND SOURCES

The following visual materials were used as references and illustrations in the creation of this historical-fiction publication. Some images have undergone modifications, including cropping, resizing, color adjustments, and other visual enhancements using Canva.

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2. Pre-Colonial Philippines and Its Lost Culture
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3. Additional Visual Reference (3-9)
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    Artist: J. Bulaong (as identified in the Pinterest pin title)
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THE WEIGHT OF THE WAVES

In the Kingdom of Marilag, the sea has long provided wealth and life to its people. But when failed harvests, disappearing merchant ships, and a devastating storm leave the kingdom vulnerable, a powerful neighboring sultanate offers aid in exchange for one thing: the marriage of Princess Hiraya to its heir, Ladja Makusug.

To Hiraya, the offer seems too generous to be without consequence. As she uncovers troubling signs behind Marilag's growing misfortunes, she begins to question whether the promised alliance is truly an act of friendship or a carefully planned attempt to claim her kingdom.

Caught between her duty to her people and the demands of powerful rulers, Hiraya must discover what it truly means to lead. For when the fate of Marilag hangs in the balance, its future may depend not on the strength of its crown, but on the courage of those who call it home.

A crown may be inherited, and a kingdom may be conquered, but neither makes a true ruler. For a throne means little when its bearer has forgotten the very people it was meant to serve.

A HISTORICAL FICTION SHORT STORY

Written by: Rashad Arkjan B. Miranda